

Rigging and Tackle Guide

Florida-Specific Rigs, Live Bait, and Tackle Setups

From the Reef to the Gulf Stream

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Introduction

Florida fishing has its own rigging language. Walk into a tackle shop in Miami, Marathon, or Key West and ask for a "knocker rig" or a "stinger rig" and they will know exactly what you mean. These rigs were developed specifically for the species, bottom types, and conditions found in South Florida waters. Generic online rigging guides written for Carolina coast drum fishing or Pacific rockfish are not going to cut it down here.

This guide covers the rigs, tackle, and live bait techniques that actually produce fish on South Florida reefs, wrecks, flats, and in the Gulf Stream. Every setup described here is field-tested and used daily by charter captains and serious recreational anglers from Miami to Key West.

Bottom Fishing Rigs

The Knocker Rig

The knocker rig is the workhorse of South Florida bottom fishing. It is simple, effective, and used for everything from yellowtail snapper to black grouper. The design keeps your sinker and bait together at the bottom, reducing snags and increasing sensitivity.

Components:

- Egg sinker (1 oz to 8 oz depending on current and depth)
- Fluorocarbon leader (30-80 lb depending on target species)
- Circle hook (1/0 to 8/0 depending on target species)
- Barrel swivel

Assembly: 1. Tie your main line (braid) to one end of a barrel swivel. 2. Cut a length of fluorocarbon leader (3-5 feet for snapper, 2-3 feet for grouper). 3. Tie one end of the leader to the other end of the barrel swivel. 4. Slide the egg sinker onto the leader BEFORE tying the hook. 5. Tie the circle hook to the free end of the leader. 6. The egg sinker should slide freely on the leader between the swivel and the hook. When the rig is in the water, the sinker slides down and rests directly on the hook eye -- hence "knocker" rig.

When to use it:

- Reef and wreck fishing in 40-250 feet
- Target species: grouper (all species), mutton snapper, mangrove snapper, hogfish
- Bottom types: reef ledges, wrecks, hard bottom, rubble

Variations:

- **Light knocker:** 1-2 oz egg sinker, 20-30 lb fluorocarbon, 1/0-3/0 hook. For yellowtail, hogfish, lanes in 15-60 feet on patch reefs.
- **Heavy knocker:** 4-8 oz egg sinker, 50-80 lb fluorocarbon, 5/0-8/0 hook. For grouper on deep wrecks in 100-250 feet with strong current.
- **No-swivel knocker:** Skip the swivel entirely and thread the egg sinker directly onto your braid main line, then tie directly to the fluorocarbon leader with a double uni knot. Simpler and one less connection point to fail.

The Chicken Rig (High-Low Rig)

The chicken rig runs two or three hooks on dropper loops above a bank sinker. It is designed for catching multiple fish per drop in deep water and is the standard rig for yellowtail snapper, vermillion snapper (beeliners), and porgy on deep reefs and wrecks.

Components:

- Fluorocarbon leader (30-40 lb), approximately 5-6 feet total length
- Bank sinker or torpedo sinker (3-8 oz)
- Two or three hooks on dropper loops (1/0-3/0 circle hooks)
- Barrel swivel at the top

Assembly: 1. Tie the barrel swivel to one end of your fluorocarbon. 2. Tie dropper loops at 18-inch intervals down the leader. You want 2-3 dropper loops. 3. Attach hooks to each dropper loop using a simple loop-through-the-eye connection. 4. Tie the bank sinker to the bottom of the leader.

When to use it:

- Deep reef fishing in 100-300+ feet
- Target species: yellowtail snapper, vermillion snapper, porgy, lane snapper
- When you want volume: the chicken rig catches two or three fish per drop

Bait:

- Squid strips (cut into 2-3 inch strips, threaded onto the hook)
- Cut bonito or little tunny (strip baits, 2-3 inches)
- Small pieces of cut sardine or ballyhoo
- Small chunks of shrimp

The Stinger Rig (Kingfish Rig)

The stinger rig is designed for king mackerel and other fish that strike from behind and bite through the tail section of bait, missing a single hook placed in the head. The stinger hook trails behind the bait to catch short-strikers.

Components:

- Wire leader (size 5-7 single-strand or 49-strand wire, 12-18 inches)
- Lead hook: 4/0-6/0 J-hook or live bait hook
- Stinger hook: size 4-6 treble hook on a 6-8 inch wire trace
- Haywire twist connections

Assembly: 1. Attach the lead hook to the wire leader using a haywire twist. 2. From the bend of the lead hook, attach a 6-8 inch trace of lighter wire. 3. Attach the treble (stinger) hook to the end of this trace. 4. Connect the top of the main wire leader to your main line via a swivel or haywire twist.

Bait rigging with stinger: 1. Hook a live blue runner, goggle eye, or threadfin through the nose with the lead hook. 2. Pin the treble stinger hook lightly into the bait's back, near the tail. 3. The bait swims naturally with both hooks in place.

When to use it:

- Slow-trolling or drift fishing for kingfish
- Flat-lining live bait behind the boat
- Also effective for wahoo, cobia, and large barracuda

The Swordfish Rig (Deepdrop)

Daytime swordfishing requires specialized heavy rigging for drops to 1,200-1,800 feet or deeper.

Components:

- 300-400 lb monofilament leader (wind-on style), 15-20 feet
- 12/0-16/0 circle hook
- 8-12 lb lead weight (attached via breakaway)
- Lightstick (green or blue chemical light)
- Bait: large squid (Illex or Humboldt) or bonito belly strips, 1-3 lbs

Assembly: 1. Crimp the circle hook to the end of the heavy mono leader. 2. Attach a lightstick 10-15 feet above the hook using a zip tie or rubber band. 3. Attach the lead weight to a breakaway loop at the bottom of the rig (below the hook). A weak link (50-lb mono loop) allows the weight to break off when a fish is hooked, reducing drag during the fight. 4. Bait with a large whole squid or layered belly strips sewn onto the hook.

Tackle:

- Electric reel (Hooker, Kristal, Lindgren-Pitman) on a stand-up bent-butt rod
- 80-130 lb class
- 65-80 lb braided main line (braid's thin diameter helps in the deep current)

Trolling Rigs and Spreads

Ballyhoo Rigging (Skirted)

The skirted ballyhoo is the most versatile trolling bait in South Florida. It imitates everything from flying fish to needlefish and catches sailfish, mahi, wahoo, tuna, and kingfish.

Basic Pin Rig: 1. Start with a thawed ballyhoo. Break the backbone by bending gently. 2. Thread a copper rigging wire through the eyes and out the chin. 3. Wrap the wire around the bait's bill 5-7 times, leaving a tag end. 4. Slide the hook (7/0-9/0 O'Shaughnessy) through the chin and up through the head so the hook eye sits at the bait's chin. 5. Wrap the wire tag end around the hook shank to secure. 6. Slide a vinyl lure skirt (Ilander, Sea Witch, chugger head) over the hook and down to the bait's nose. 7. The finished bait should swim straight when trolled at 6-8 knots. If it spins, re-rig -- a spinning bait catches nothing.

Trolling Spread Layout

A standard South Florida trolling spread for sailfish, mahi, and wahoo:

Position 1 and 2 -- Flat Lines (port and starboard):

- 50-75 feet back from the transom
- Skirted ballyhoo or Ilander-style lure
- 30-50 lb class rod and reel
- No weight, running on the surface wake

Position 3 and 4 -- Rigger Lines (port and starboard outriggers):

- 100-150 feet back
- Skirted ballyhoo on outrigger clips
- 20-30 lb class for sailfish, 30-50 lb for mahi/wahoo
- Running in the spread behind the prop wash

Position 5 -- Shotgun (center, long):

- 200-300 feet back, center of the spread
- Small feather, cedar plug, or deep-diving plug
- Runs in clean water behind the entire spread

Position 6 -- Bridge Teaser (optional):

- A hookless teaser (dredge, squid chain, or bird) fished from the bridge or hardtop
- Designed to attract fish to the spread

Trolling speeds:

- Sailfish and mahi: 6-8 knots
- Wahoo: 10-14 knots (use high-speed lures -- wahoo bombs, jet heads)
- Mixed spread: 7-8 knots is a good compromise

Wahoo-Specific Trolling

Wahoo require a different approach from standard billfish trolling:

- **Speed kills.** Troll faster -- 10-14 knots minimum. Wahoo are the fastest fish in the ocean and prefer high-speed lures.
- **Wire required.** Use #7 to #10 single-strand wire leader (12-18 inches) or heavy fluorocarbon (130+ lb). Wahoo teeth shred anything lighter.
- **Lure selection:** Wahoo bombs (heavy, torpedo-shaped jet lures), high-speed Rapala X-Raps, Yo-Zuri Bonitas, and rigged swimming ballyhoo with chin weights for deep running.
- **Planers and downriggers:** Wahoo often feed 30-80 feet below the surface. A sea striker planer or downrigger gets your lure to the right depth.

Live Bait: Catching and Keeping It

Pilchards (Scaled Sardines)

The universal live bait of South Florida. If you can only learn one bait technique, learn how to catch pilchards with a cast net.

Where to find them:

- Sandy flats near inlets at first light (Haulover, Government Cut, Key Largo channels)
- Bridge shadows during tidal flow
- Along seawall edges and marina docks at dawn
- Near shallow grass flats with clean water

How to catch them:

- 10-12 foot radius cast net, 3/8-inch mesh (the standard "pilchard net")
- Look for dark patches on sand bottom, nervous water, or dimpling on the surface
- Chum the surface with a handful of canned Jack mackerel juice mixed with sand to draw them up into a tight ball
- Throw the net flat and fast when the school is balled up

How to keep them alive:

- Aerated live well with round corners (pilchards bash themselves to death in square wells)
- Minimum 30-gallon capacity for a day of fishing, 60+ gallons for a full day offshore
- Change water regularly or use a raw-water pump recirculating system
- Do not overcrowd -- 2-3 dozen per 30 gallons maximum
- Keep the well shaded; direct sun kills bait fast

Goggle Eyes (Bigeye Scad)

The premium live bait for sailfish and big kingfish. Tougher and livelier than pilchards, goggle eyes swim aggressively on a kite clip and can survive for hours.

Where to find them:

- Under bridge lights at night (79th Street Causeway, MacArthur Causeway, Julia Tuttle)
- Haulover Inlet jetties at night
- Over the reef in 90-130 feet during the day
- Around channel markers with lights

How to catch them:

- Sabiki rigs (6-hook, size 8-10 gold hooks) with a 1-2 oz weight
- Lower the sabiki to the depth where you see marks on the fishfinder
- Jig gently -- small up-and-down motions
- At night under lights, the fish are often 5-20 feet below the surface

- Can also be caught on tiny hooks (size 10-12) baited with a small piece of shrimp

How to keep them alive:

- Larger, tougher bait -- easier to keep alive than pilchards
- Round live well with strong aeration
- Do not mix with pilchards (goggle eyes will eat smaller baits)
- Can be held overnight in a flow-through live well or bait pen

Ballyhoo

For live bait: Catch on sabiki rigs over shallow grass flats and sand patches in 10-30 feet. Extremely fragile -- handle gently, use a de-hooking tool, and place in the live well immediately. Live ballyhoo is deadly for slow-trolling for sailfish.

For dead/frozen bait: Purchase from any South Florida tackle shop. Brined ballyhoo (salted and preserved) rig better and stay on the hook longer than fresh-thawed. Rigging technique is described in the trolling section above.

Blue Runners (Hardtails)

The go-to live bait for amberjack, large grouper, and big kingfish. Blue runners are tough, swim hard, and attract predators with their constant movement.

Where to find them:

- Channel markers and buoys
- Bridge pilings
- Artificial reef structures in 30-80 feet
- Around anchored boats (they stage in the current shadow)

How to catch them:

- Sabiki rigs with small cut bait (squid, shrimp) on the hooks
- Small hooks (size 4-6) baited with cut shrimp fished near structure
- They also hit small jigs and spoons

Kite Fishing Setups

Kite fishing is the signature technique of South Florida sailfishing. The system uses a fishing kite to deploy live baits at the surface, suspended from the kite line by release clips. The splashing, struggling bait on the surface is irresistible to sailfish, tuna, mahi, and kingfish.

Basic Kite System Components

Kite and Kite Reel:

- Fishing kite (SFE Kite, Fish Razr, or similar -- designed for fishing, not a toy kite)
- Kite reel: electric (preferred) or manual reel mounted on the outrigger or hardtop
- Kite line: 80-100 lb Dacron or braided line

Release Clips:

- Snap-on release clips (Black's, Aftco, or similar) attach to the kite line at intervals
- Typically 3 clips per kite, spaced 50-75 feet apart
- The clip holds the fishing line and releases when a fish strikes, transferring the load to the fishing rod

Fishing Rods and Reels (one per clip, typically 3 per kite):

- Spinning reels loaded with 20-lb braid, 30-lb fluorocarbon leader (8-12 feet)
- 7-foot medium-heavy spinning rod
- Circle hook (5/0-7/0) for clean hookups and easy release

Kite Deployment

1. Motor to your starting position on the reef edge (90-180 feet of water). 2. Turn the bow into the wind or current (kites fly best into the wind). 3. Launch the kite off the stern on the downwind side. 4. As the kite gains altitude, clip the first fishing line to the closest release clip. 5. Let out more kite line and clip the second and third fishing lines at intervals. 6. Adjust kite line and fishing line lengths so each bait is suspended AT the surface, splashing but not submerged and not airborne. 7. Deploy a second kite off the opposite side for a full 6-bait spread.

Kite Fishing Bait

- **Primary:** Live goggle eyes, hooked through the nose with a circle hook
- **Secondary:** Live pilchards (smaller profile, shorter lifespan on the clip)
- **Alternative:** Live blue runners (tough bait, larger profile for bigger fish)

Reading the Bite

When a sailfish or other fish approaches a kite bait: 1. You will see the bait's splash pattern change -- it gets frantic. 2. The fish may "light up" (change color) as it attacks -- visible in clear water. 3. The clip releases and the line goes slack momentarily. 4. DO NOT SET THE HOOK. Free-spool the reel, let the fish eat, wait for the line to come tight. 5. Once the line is tight and the fish is running, engage the drag. The circle hook does the rest.

Leader Materials and Knots

Fluorocarbon Leader

The standard leader material for South Florida reef and offshore fishing. Fluorocarbon is nearly invisible underwater, abrasion-resistant, and sinks (keeping baits down).

Recommended pound test by application:

- Yellowtail snapper, hogfish: 15-20 lb
- Mutton snapper, mangrove snapper: 25-30 lb
- Grouper (open bottom): 40-60 lb
- Grouper (heavy structure): 60-80 lb
- Sailfish (kite fishing): 25-30 lb

- Mahi: 30-40 lb
- Amberjack: 50-80 lb
- Cobia: 40-60 lb

Wire Leader

Required for kingfish, wahoo, and barracuda -- any fish with teeth that cut monofilament and fluorocarbon.

- **Single-strand:** #5 to #7 for kingfish, #7 to #10 for wahoo. Use haywire twist connections. Stiff but reliable.
- **49-strand cable:** More flexible than single-strand, less prone to kinking. Use crimped connections with appropriate sleeves.
- **Length:** Keep wire leaders short -- 12-18 inches. Longer wire reduces bites from leader-shy fish.

Essential Knots

FG Knot: The preferred braid-to-fluorocarbon connection. Slim, passes through guides smoothly, and tests near 100% line strength. Takes practice to learn but is worth the effort. Used to connect your braid main line to fluorocarbon leader.

Uni Knot (Double Uni): The backup braid-to-leader knot when you need to tie up fast on the water. Not as slim as the FG but still very strong.

Loop Knot (Rapala or Perfection Loop): Gives your bait or lure freedom of movement. Use for tying hooks when you want maximum bait action (live bait presentations).

Snell Knot: For circle hooks when bottom fishing. The snell keeps the hook oriented correctly for a proper corner-of-the-jaw hookset.

Dropper Loop: Essential for chicken rigs. Creates a perpendicular loop in your leader for attaching hooks on a high-low rig.

Bimini Twist: A double-line loop that absorbs shock. Used as the first step in connecting heavy leader to braid in IGFA-class tournament rigging.

Rod and Reel Recommendations by Application

Reef/Bottom Fishing (General)

- **Rod:** 6.5-7 foot medium-heavy conventional or spinning
- **Reel:** 4000-6000 size spinning or 15-30 class conventional
- **Line:** 30-50 lb braid main, 30-60 lb fluorocarbon leader
- **Use:** Knocker rigs, chicken rigs, patch reef fishing

Kite Fishing / Sailfish

- **Rod:** 7-7.5 foot medium spinning
- **Reel:** 5000-6000 size spinning (Shimano Stella, Penn Slammer, Daiwa Saltiga class)
- **Line:** 20 lb braid main, 25-30 lb fluorocarbon leader
- **Use:** Kite baits, live bait drifting for sailfish

Grouper / Wreck Fishing (Heavy)

- **Rod:** 5.5-6.5 foot heavy conventional (stand-up style)
- **Reel:** 30-50 class conventional (Shimano Tiagra, Penn International class)
- **Line:** 65-80 lb braid, 60-100 lb fluorocarbon leader
- **Use:** Big grouper on wrecks, amberjack, deep dropping

Trolling (Offshore)

- **Rod:** 5.5-6 foot trolling rod, roller guides
- **Reel:** 30-50 class conventional
- **Line:** 30-50 lb mono or braid, 60-100 lb fluorocarbon or wire leader
- **Use:** Trolling for mahi, sailfish, wahoo, tuna

Flats Fishing (Light Tackle)

- **Rod:** 7-7.5 foot medium-light spinning
- **Reel:** 2500-3500 size spinning
- **Line:** 10-15 lb braid, 12-20 lb fluorocarbon leader
- **Use:** Bonefish, permit (light), seatrout, snook

Tackle Maintenance in the Salt

South Florida's saltwater environment destroys tackle fast. A \$500 reel will seize up in months without proper care.

After every trip: 1. Rinse all rods and reels with fresh water. Not a blast from the hose -- a gentle shower that flushes salt from guides, reel bodies, and drag systems. 2. Spray reel bodies and rod guides with a light corrosion inhibitor (Corrosion-X, BoeshieldT-9, or Reel-X). 3. Wipe down rod blanks and reel seats with a damp cloth. 4. Open the bail on spinning reels to let the line roller dry. 5. Back off the drag on all reels so the washers do not compress and set.

Monthly: 1. Check all guides for nicks and grooves (run a cotton swab through each guide -- if it catches, the guide needs replacement). 2. Grease reel handles and lubricate moving parts per manufacturer specifications. 3. Inspect line for nicks, fraying, or UV damage. Replace the top 50-100 feet of braid if it looks worn. 4. Check all crimps, swivels, and hardware for corrosion.

Final Note

The right rig in the right place makes the difference between a full fish box and a long boat ride. Florida fishing is specific -- what works in the Carolinas or the Gulf coast of Alabama is not necessarily what works on Miami's reef line or in the Keys backcountry. Learn these rigs, practice tying them at home (not on the boat in 3-foot seas), and keep pre-tied rigs in a tackle box organized by application. When the bite is hot, the last thing you want is to be fumbling with crimps and dropper loops while fish are eating.

Tight lines.

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DISCLAIMER: Fishing techniques and tackle recommendations are based on general best practices for South Florida waters. Individual results vary. Always follow manufacturer guidelines for tackle use and maintenance. Fishing regulations change -- verify current FWC rules before fishing.